

MUJEEB FARUQUI

FERTILE GROUND Farmers loading sacks of fertilisers from a government outlet in Huzur Tehsil, Bhopal, Feb. 18

government outlet. The technology is powered by AgriStack, a government database that currently lists the crops planted by 94 per cent of the state's farmers, complete with the acreage held by them. The fertiliser quantity is recommended by the Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR) and can be exceeded upon request.

NO QUEUE, JUST QR CODE

Around 177,000 farmers availed the service last year via nearly 650 retailers. The online linkage to ownership of land ensures "only genuine farmers get fertiliser", says agriculture secretary Nishant Warwade, though an option to buy offline has been kept open for the large number of tenant farmers in the state. "The platform does not distinguish between small, medium and large farmers. The inherent advantage [held by the third category] in stocking fertilisers has now gone," adds Warwade, hinting at the larger issue of hoarding in anticipation of a shortage. "Our assessment pointed out that while there were distribution issues at some places, the shortage was mainly self-created," he says.

Takeaways

- **A new online portal promises faster access to fertilisers in a state that has seen protests and even deaths over shortages for a year**
- **Piloted in three districts last year, around 180,000 farmers have already used the service and plans are on to roll it out across the state**
- **Database-backed linkage to land owned by farmers could stem hoarding and black market sales**
- **Officials warn of soil damage due to excessive fertiliser use, a worrying trend in recent years**

The e-VIKAS initiative seems to have had an instant effect. The number of reported law-and-order incidents around fertiliser in Vidisha went down from 12 in 2024 to one last year. It was the same for Shajapur (five to nil) and Jabalpur (eight to one). Fertiliser sales also saw an increase, with urea recording a nine per cent rise in sales in the pilot districts in one year. This seems to have had a spillover effect in other districts as well, which saw a 22 per cent increase. However, NPK (Nitrogen, Phosphorous, Potassium) sales came down by six per cent in the pilot districts, even though they remained the same in the remaining districts.

THE PERILS OF EXCESS

Even as the government has moved to solve one problem, other problems persist. And none more than the overusage of NPK, three key macronutrients, per hectare. In the case of agricultural bounty, more is not always better. Yet NPK use per hectare has steadily increased in MP over the years, seeing a nearly three-fold jump between 2001 and 2021. To take but one example, ICAR recommends 90:60:40 kg per ha. NPK usage in wheat, yet producers who are in 'irrigated late sowing conditions' i.e. the best wheat-producing belt in MP, are applying as much as 110-120 kg of nitrogen per ha. Farmers mistakenly believe that more fertiliser equals more yield, a claim that is not scientifically supported. In this scenario, if the state tries to pull back on the fertiliser being sold, it could aggravate the already incensed farming electorate. Plans are on to identify and sensitise those exceeding ICAR-recommended amounts.

Even as the initiative is being implemented in all MP districts for the current rabi season, with plans to scale it nationally on the prime minister's desk, it's facing a challenge in the Jabalpur High Court. The Krishi Adaan Vikreta Sangh is demanding that farmers be allowed to continue buying fertiliser directly from stores, a move that, critics say, could fuel hoarding and black market sales. Though the petition has not yet been dealt with, perhaps its very existence is proof of the need for the initiative to be rolled out even faster. ■